Nevertheless due to the continuities of the region's topography, economy, religious aspirations and social fabric, the failures of 170 years ago do still hold important warnings for us today. It is still not too late to learn some lessons from the mistakes of the British in 1842. Otherwise, the west's fourth war in the country looks certain to end with as few political gains as the first three, and like them to terminate in an embarrassing withdrawal after a humiliating defeat, with Afghanistan yet again left in tribal chaos and quite possibly ruled by the same government which the war was originally fought to overthrow.

As George Lawrence wrote to the London *Times* just before Britain blundered into the Second Anglo-Afghan War thirty years later, 'a new generation has arisen which, instead of profiting from the solemn lessons of the past, is willing and eager to embroil us in the affairs of that turbulent and unhappy country . . . Although military disasters may be avoided, an advance now, however successful in a military point of view, would not fail to turn out to be as politically useless . . . The disaster of the Retreat from Kabul should stand forever as a warning to the Statesmen of the future not to repeat the policies that bore such bitter fruit in 1839–42.'

Despite the central strategic significance of this region, good writing on Afghan history is surprisingly thin on the ground, and what there is invariably uses printed accounts in English or the much mined India Office Archives in London. While the story of the First Anglo-Afghan War has been told many times, in forms ranging from great Victorian three-volume histories to the antics of Flashman, there is still virtually no published material about the war, even in the most specialist academic publications, which utilises contemporary Afghan sources from the early nineteenth century, and which presents Afghan accounts of being invaded and occupied, or makes use of the records of the anti-colonial Afghan resistance.[5]

The First Anglo-Afghan War is a uniquely well-documented conflict and in the writing of it I have made use of a variety of new sources from all sides of the battle lines. Hundreds of tattered letters and blood-stained diaries belonging to the British participants in the war have appeared from trunks in Home Counties attics over the last few years and I have accessed